

# **EXPECTING & ANXIOUS**

A CBT Workbook for  
Pregnancy Anxiety

Evidence-Based Tools for Managing  
Worry During Pregnancy

**Daniel Tesfamariam**

# EXPECTING & ANXIOUS

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Not a substitute for prenatal care or mental health treatment.

**If you are experiencing severe anxiety, tell your OB or midwife.**

# ANXIETY DURING PREGNANCY IS COMMON

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Up to 25% of pregnant women experience significant anxiety.

**You are NOT alone. You are NOT a bad mom for feeling this way.**

Common pregnancy worries:

- Is the baby healthy?
- Will something go wrong during delivery?
- Am I eating/doing everything right?
- What if I'm a bad mother?
- Financial fears about supporting a baby
- Relationship changes
- Loss of identity/freedom
- History of miscarriage or loss

## **When worry becomes TOO MUCH:**

Constant dread, can't sleep, avoiding appointments, checking obsessively, physical symptoms (racing heart, nausea beyond morning sickness), intrusive thoughts about harm to baby.

# COGNITIVE DISTORTIONS IN PREGNANCY

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## **CATASTROPHIZING:**

'One glass of wine before I knew = my baby will have problems'

## **WHAT-IFS:**

'What if the ultrasound shows something terrible?'

## **PROBABILITY OVERESTIMATION:**

'I just KNOW something will go wrong with delivery'

## **INTOLERANCE OF UNCERTAINTY:**

'I need to KNOW the baby is okay RIGHT NOW'

## **SHOULD STATEMENTS:**

'I SHOULD be enjoying every moment of pregnancy'

## **EMOTIONAL REASONING:**

'I feel anxious, so something must be wrong'

## PREGNANCY THOUGHT RECORD (1/5)

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Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Week of pregnancy: \_\_\_\_

Situation/Trigger: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxious thought: \_\_\_\_\_

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Distortion type: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxiety level (0-10): \_\_\_\_

**Evidence FOR this worry:**

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**Evidence AGAINST this worry:**

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---

Balanced thought: \_\_\_\_\_

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Anxiety level AFTER (0-10): \_\_\_\_

What I can CONTROL: \_\_\_\_\_

What I need to LET GO: \_\_\_\_\_

## PREGNANCY THOUGHT RECORD (2/5)

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Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Week of pregnancy: \_\_\_\_

Situation/Trigger: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxious thought: \_\_\_\_\_

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Distortion type: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxiety level (0-10): \_\_\_\_

**Evidence FOR this worry:**

---

**Evidence AGAINST this worry:**

---

---

Balanced thought: \_\_\_\_\_

---

Anxiety level AFTER (0-10): \_\_\_\_

What I can CONTROL: \_\_\_\_\_

What I need to LET GO: \_\_\_\_\_

## PREGNANCY THOUGHT RECORD (3/5)

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Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Week of pregnancy: \_\_\_\_

Situation/Trigger: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxious thought: \_\_\_\_\_

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Distortion type: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxiety level (0-10): \_\_\_\_

**Evidence FOR this worry:**

---

**Evidence AGAINST this worry:**

---

---

Balanced thought: \_\_\_\_\_

---

Anxiety level AFTER (0-10): \_\_\_\_

What I can CONTROL: \_\_\_\_\_

What I need to LET GO: \_\_\_\_\_

## PREGNANCY THOUGHT RECORD (4/5)

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Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Week of pregnancy: \_\_\_\_

Situation/Trigger: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxious thought: \_\_\_\_\_

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Distortion type: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxiety level (0-10): \_\_\_\_

**Evidence FOR this worry:**

---

**Evidence AGAINST this worry:**

---

---

Balanced thought: \_\_\_\_\_

---

Anxiety level AFTER (0-10): \_\_\_\_

What I can CONTROL: \_\_\_\_\_

What I need to LET GO: \_\_\_\_\_



## PREGNANCY THOUGHT RECORD (5/5)

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Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Week of pregnancy: \_\_\_\_

Situation/Trigger: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxious thought: \_\_\_\_\_

---

Distortion type: \_\_\_\_\_

Anxiety level (0-10): \_\_\_\_

**Evidence FOR this worry:**

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**Evidence AGAINST this worry:**

---

---

Balanced thought: \_\_\_\_\_

---

Anxiety level AFTER (0-10): \_\_\_\_

What I can CONTROL: \_\_\_\_\_

What I need to LET GO: \_\_\_\_\_

[illegible]

# BIRTH ANXIETY PREPARATION

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## My specific fears about birth:

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_

## Things I CAN control about my birth:

(birth plan preferences, support person, environment)

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## Things I CANNOT control (practice releasing):

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## My coping plan for labor:

Breathing technique: \_\_\_\_\_

Mantras: \_\_\_\_\_

Support person & their role: \_\_\_\_\_

## POSTPARTUM ANXIETY PREVENTION PLAN

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### Planning NOW reduces risk later:

My support team after birth:

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ How they'll help: \_\_\_\_\_

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ How they'll help: \_\_\_\_\_

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ How they'll help: \_\_\_\_\_

### Warning signs to watch for:

- Excessive worry about baby's safety
- Inability to sleep (even when baby sleeps)
- Intrusive scary thoughts
- Needing to check baby constantly
- Irritability/rage
- Physical symptoms (racing heart, nausea)

If I notice these, I will: \_\_\_\_\_

Provider to call: \_\_\_\_\_

# BABY HEALTH WORRY MANAGEMENT

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## Rules for Dr. Google:

- Set a time limit (10 min max)
- Only use trusted sources (OB's recommendations)
- If searching makes anxiety WORSE, close the browser
- Write down questions for your next appointment instead
- One search, then STOP. Don't go down the rabbit hole.

## Questions for my next appointment:

1. \_\_\_\_\_
2. \_\_\_\_\_
3. \_\_\_\_\_
4. \_\_\_\_\_
5. \_\_\_\_\_
6. \_\_\_\_\_

Reassurances from my provider: \_\_\_\_\_

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# MINDFUL PREGNANCY PRACTICES

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## **Morning intention:**

Before getting up, place hands on belly and set one calm intention.

## **Mindful eating:**

One meal/day, eat slowly. Notice textures, flavors. Thank your body.

## **Movement:**

Gentle yoga, walking, swimming. Focus on how movement FEELS, not looks.

## **Kick counts as meditation:**

During kick counts, breathe and connect. Not just counting - bonding.

## **Evening gratitude:**

3 things you're grateful for today. One about your body, one about baby.

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 1

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

Baby connection moment this week:

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 2

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

Baby connection moment this week:

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse



# WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 3

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

**Baby connection moment this week:**

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 4

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

Baby connection moment this week:

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

# WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 5

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

**Baby connection moment this week:**

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 6

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

Baby connection moment this week:

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

# WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 7

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

**Baby connection moment this week:**

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

WEEKLY ANXIETY TRACKER - Week 8

Week of: \_\_\_\_\_ Pregnancy week: \_\_\_\_

| Day | Anxiety (0-10) | Main Trigger | Coping Used |
|-----|----------------|--------------|-------------|
| Mon |                |              |             |
| Tue |                |              |             |
| Wed |                |              |             |
| Thu |                |              |             |
| Fri |                |              |             |
| Sat |                |              |             |
| Sun |                |              |             |

Baby connection moment this week:

Something I'm looking forward to: \_\_\_\_\_

Self-care I did: \_\_\_\_\_

Avg anxiety this week: \_\_\_\_ Compared to last week: better/same/worse

# MY BIRTH PREFERENCES

(Not a rigid plan - preferences reduce anxiety)

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Support people: \_\_\_\_\_

Environment: \_\_\_\_\_

Pain management preference: \_\_\_\_\_

Music/comfort items: \_\_\_\_\_

If plans change, I want: \_\_\_\_\_

After birth, I'd like: \_\_\_\_\_

Feeding plan: \_\_\_\_\_

**My mantra for birth:** \_\_\_\_\_

Reminder: Healthy mom + healthy baby = successful birth, no matter how.

## SUPPORT NETWORK FOR NEW MOTHERHOOD

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### Line up support NOW (before baby comes):

Person who will bring meals:

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Person who will help with older kids:

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Person I can call crying at 3am:

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Lactation consultant:

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Postpartum therapist (have number ready):

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Mom group/community:

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Partner's specific postpartum responsibilities:

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# WHEN TO SEEK HELP

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## **Talk to your provider if:**

- Anxiety interferes with daily functioning
- You can't sleep even when you have the chance
- You're avoiding prenatal appointments out of fear
- You have intrusive thoughts of harm (to self or baby)
- You feel disconnected from the pregnancy
- Physical symptoms that won't ease (racing heart, panic attacks)
- You're using substances to cope

## **Resources:**

Postpartum Support International: 1-800-944-4773

Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741

Your OB/midwife's after-hours number: \_\_\_\_\_

**Asking for help makes you a GOOD mom, not a weak one.**